

Garden Friendly

A gang of four kicks off a pocket-sized green revolution to revitalise their concrete environment

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GREENING THEIR CITY,
NOOK BY GARDEN.

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

Even as Bangaloreans grieved at the sight of thousands of trees being felled for the city's metro project, a motley group of four friends decided that it was time "to stop moping" and get into the thick of things. "When we look around we see nothing of the Bangalore we grew up in. Trees, old buildings and gardens have all been replaced by monstrous concrete structures. We can either crib and be nostalgic or do something," says Reena Chengappa, one of the founders of My Sunny Balcony. The foursome, who believe that everyone should have a garden in their homes or terraces, no matter how little the space, have greened balconies as little as 2x2 ft. Whether it is staircase landings, walkways, unused corridors or window sills—My Sunny Balcony manages to create pleasing gardens.

The group comprises Shailesh Deshpande, who works in an environmental consultancy, Athreya Chidambi, a web designer, Chengappa, who quit her IT job, and Sriram Aravumudan, a freelance writer and garden consultant. "There are people with as little as four feet of balcony space and they are thrilled to bits

when we create a garden for them," says Chengappa. The group pools in ideas and creates an artist's impression for their clients after which the garden is ready in less than two weeks. They use flowering shrubs and bamboo groves, besides a whole lot of creepers, flowers and ferns.

My Sunny Balcony also offers maintenance contracts to its clients to ensure that their gardens continue to flourish. "There was so much we had to learn before we started off; we still tell people that we are not architects or landscape experts, we are simply gardeners and we include the client in everything that we do. Because once we leave, it is they who have to live with and nurture the garden," says Chengappa. The group has not advertised or marketed the company and yet, thanks to word of mouth, have managed to complete 25 projects in the last seven months. Their present offers include "gift a garden", where people can gift each other gardens to be designed by the four friends. With their efforts, Bangalore just might regain its lost reputation as the Garden City.